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Knife

5.20.4 Knife

References:

Hebrew חֶרֶב, צוּר (cherev tsur) JOS 5:2, JOS 5:3

Hebrew מַאֲכֶלֶת (ma’akeleth) GEN 22:6, GEN 22:10, JDG 19:29, PRO 30:14

Hebrew שַׂכִּין (sakin) PRO 23:2

Description and usage:

Knife of iron and wood, Cave of the Letters, Nahal Hever (132–135 CE), Israel Museum (© Chamberi, CC BY-SA 3.0, via Wikimedia Commons)The knife was a small blade with a handle, used for cutting meat and other food.

Translation:

The Hebrew words listed above refer to a sharp knife, which probably was also pointed. Translators should avoid a word that is limited to the rather blunt kind of instrument with which things are spread on bread.

JOS 5:2; JOS 5:3: The Hebrew word *cherev* normally refers to a sword (see 2.3 Sword<REALIA:2.3>). Here it is used in the context of the delicate operation of circumcision, so it is clear that a smaller implement is in view. The Hebrew modifier *tsur* indicates that this knife was made from flint, an extremely hard type of quartz stone. From ancient times tools and weapons were made from flint by chipping or flaking to produce very sharp edges.